

Word family: **say / says / said / saying**

Base word: say

Third-person singular: says

Past tense: said

Past participle: said

-ing form: saying

Related forms: saying

Useful constructions/extensions: say something, say yes/no, say that..., say to someone, say something to someone, what did you say?, let's say, say + number, say so, have a say, needless to say, that is to say, as the saying goes

Part of speech: mainly verb (動詞) / noun in fixed expressions (固定名詞用法)

Your passage contains:

> “I felt that if I **said no**, I would regret it later.”

Here, **say** means:

to express the response “no” verbally — in other words, to refuse the opportunity.

Meaning in this passage

In:

> **if I said no**

say means:

to express a particular answer or response in words.

The phrase **say no** means:

refuse / decline / not agree to do something.

Meaning: To express a response verbally.

繁體中文: 用說話表達某個回答／態度；這裡的 say no 指拒絕、不接受

中文翻譯:

> “I felt that if I said no, I would regret it later.”

「我覺得如果我**拒絕了／說不接受**，之後一定會後悔。」

So:

****say no = 表示拒絕／不接受****

This is the exact passage meaning.

1. ****say + words/content(說出內容) — 說;講****

This is the broad core meaning.

****Meaning:**** To express words or information verbally.

Practice 1

> “She ****said**** something quietly before the presentation.”

「簡報前她小聲****說了些話****。」

Practice 2

> “I didn’t know what to ****say****.”

「我不知道該****說甚麼****。」

****say = 用說話表達具體內容、句子或訊息****

The focus is usually on ****what is said****, not on the act of speaking itself.

2. ****say yes/no(表示同意／拒絕) — 答應;拒絕****

This is the exact construction used in your passage.

Practice 3 — Original

> “If I ****said no****, I would regret it later.”

「如果我****拒絕／說不接受****，我之後會後悔。」

Practice 4

> “She **said yes** to the opportunity.”

「她**答應了／接受了**這個機會。」

Practice 5

> “He **said no** to the proposal.”

「他**拒絕了**這項提案。」

say yes/no = 用肯定／否定回答表達接受、同意或拒絕

This often functions almost like:

- * accept
- * agree
- * refuse
- * decline

depending on context.

3. **say that + clause** (說.....) — 表示; 說明

A major reporting pattern.

Practice 6

> “She **said that** she was nervous.”

「她**說自己很緊張**。」

Practice 7

> “The manager **said that** the event had gone well.”

「經理**說活動進行得很好**。」

say that + clause = 用語言陳述某項資訊、意見或事實

4. **say + direct quotation (直接說出某句話) — 說:「……」**

Practice 8

> “She **said**, ‘Don’t worry.’”

「她**說**：「不要擔心。」」

Practice 9

> “He **said**, ‘You did well.’”

「他**說**：「你做得很好。」」

say + quoted words = 直接引述某人實際說出的內容

5. **say something to someone (對某人說某事) — 對……說**

A crucial grammar pattern.

Practice 10

> “She **said something encouraging to me**.”

「她**對我說了一些鼓勵的話**。」

Practice 11

> “What did the manager **say to you**?”

「經理**對你說了甚麼**？」

say something to someone = 把某段內容說給某人聽

Important:

>  say something **to** someone

not:

>  say someone something

for ordinary modern English.

6. **say = express an opinion/view(表示意見) — 說;認為**

Practice 12

> “I would **say** the presentation went well.”

「我會**說／認為**這次簡報進行得不錯。」

Practice 13

> “What would you **say** is the biggest challenge?”

「你會**認為／說**最大的挑戰是甚麼？」

say = 表達自己的判斷、看法或評價

This is especially common in conversational English.

7. **I'd say...(我會說／我認為) — 我認為;我估計**

A very common conversational pattern.

Practice 14

> “I'd **say** preparation was the key.”

「我會**認為**充分準備是關鍵。」

Practice 15

> “I'd **say** about two hundred people attended.”

「我會**估計**大約有二百人出席。」

I'd say = 用較委婉方式提出個人判斷、估計或意見

8. **say = estimate / approximately (假設／估計) — 大約; 假設**

A useful discourse use.

Practice 16

> “There were, **say**, two hundred people in the room.”

「房間裡大約有, **比如說／估計**二百人。」

Practice 17

> “Let’s **say** the presentation takes fifteen minutes.”

「我們**假設／就當**簡報需時十五分鐘。」

say = 用來提出一個例子、估計數字或假設情況

9. **let’s say... (假設.....) — 假設; 比方說**

Practice 18

> “**Let’s say** you forget one sentence. What should you do?”

「**假設**你忘了一句, 你應該怎樣做？」

Practice 19

> “**Let’s say** the audience asks a difficult question.”

「**假設**觀眾問了一條很難的問題。」

let’s say = 提出一個假設情況, 方便討論、估算或舉例

10. **say = indicate in writing (文字寫著) — 寫著; 表示**

A genuinely different sense.

Practice 20

> “The email **says** the meeting starts at nine.”

「電郵**寫著／說明**會議九點開始。」

Practice 21

> “The sign **says** ‘Exit’.”

「標誌上**寫著**「出口」。」

document/sign/message says = 某段文字、標誌或文件載有／顯示某項內容

No person is literally speaking.

11. **say** = show/indicate information (顯示) — 顯示; 表明

This extends beyond literal written words.

Practice 22

> “The report **says** sales have increased.”

「報告**顯示／指出**銷售額有所上升。」

Practice 23

> “What does the data **say**?”

「這些數據**顯示甚麼**？」

say = 資料、報告或證據傳達／顯示某項結論或資訊

12. **say** a name/word (說出名稱／詞) — 說; 讀出

Practice 24

> “Could you **say** your name again?”

「你可以再**說一次**你的名字嗎？」

Practice 25

> “How do you ****say**** this word?”

「這個詞要怎樣****說／讀****？」

****say + word/name = 把某個詞、名稱或短語用聲音說出來****

13. ****say something clearly/loudly (以某方式說) — 清楚／大聲說****

Practice 26

> “Please ****say it clearly****.”

「請****說清楚一點****。」

Practice 27

> “She ****said it loudly**** so everyone could hear.”

「她****大聲說了出來****, 讓所有人都聽到。」

****say + manner adverb = 以某種方式說出具體內容****

14. ****say hello/goodbye/thanks/sorry (說招呼／道歉／道謝) — 打招呼; 道別; 道謝; 道歉****

A highly useful collocational family.

Practice 28

> “I ****said hello**** to the audience.”

「我向觀眾****打了招呼****。」

Practice 29

> “Don’t forget to ****say thank you****.”

「不要忘記****道謝****。」

Common:

- * say hello
- * say goodbye
- * say thanks
- * say sorry
- * say congratulations

****say + social expression = 用語言作出某種社交回應／禮貌表達****

15. ****say a prayer(祈禱) — 禱告; 念禱文****

A fixed religious expression.

Practice 30

> “They ****said a prayer**** before the ceremony.”

「他們在儀式前****作了祈禱／念了禱文****。」

Practice 31

> “She quietly ****said a prayer****.”

「她靜靜地****祈禱****。」

****say a prayer = 以口頭或內心方式念出／進行祈禱****

16. ****say so(這樣說／表示如此) — 這樣說; 表示是這樣****

A very common substitute expression.

Practice 32

> “If you think the plan is too difficult, just ****say so****.”

「如果你覺得計劃太難, 就直接****這樣說／說出來****。」

Practice 33

> “Nobody **said so**, but everyone looked nervous.”

「雖然沒有人**明說**，但大家看起來都很緊張。」

say so = 說出前面所提到的那個意見、判斷或內容，避免重複完整句子

17. **if you say so(既然你這樣說) — 如果你這樣說;你說是就是吧**

A common conversational expression.

Practice 34

> “You’ll be fine.”

> “If you **say so**.”

「你會沒事的。」

「**既然你這樣說吧／希望你說得對。**」

Practice 35

> “This is the best option.”

> “If you **say so**.”

「這是最好的選擇。」

「**你說是就是吧。**」

if you say so = 表示暫時接受對方的說法，有時帶懷疑或不完全信服

Tone matters greatly.

18. **who says...?(誰說……?) — 誰說……?／未必如此**

A common rhetorical use.

Practice 36

> “Who **says** nervous people can't give good presentations?”

「**誰說**緊張的人不能做好簡報？」

Practice 37

> “Who **says** you have to be perfect?”

「**誰說**你一定要完美？」

who says...? = 質疑某個假設、規則或普遍看法是否真的成立

19. **you can say that again** (我非常同意) — 說得對; 我完全同意

A fixed informal expression.

Practice 38

> “That presentation was stressful.”

> “You can **say that again**.”

「那次簡報壓力很大。」

「**你說得太對了／我完全同意。**」

Practice 39

> “Preparation takes time.”

> “You can **say that again**.”

「準備很花時間。」

「**一點也沒錯。**」

you can say that again = 非常同意對方剛才說的話

It usually does not literally request repetition.

20. ****that's not to say...**(這並不是說.....) — 這不代表;並不是說******

A useful discourse expression.

Practice 40

> “I'm more confident now. ****That's not to say**** I never feel nervous.”

「我現在更有自信。****但這並不是說****我完全不會緊張。」

Practice 41

> “Preparation helps. ****That's not to say**** mistakes never happen.”

「準備有幫助。****但這並不代表****永遠不會犯錯。」

****that's not to say = 防止前面的說法被過度理解;這並不意味著.....****

21. ****that is to say**(也就是說) — 也就是說;換句話說******

A formal clarifying expression.

Practice 42

> “The task was optional—that is to ****say****, nobody had to do it.”

「這項任務是自願的, ****也就是說****, 沒有人一定要做。」

Practice 43

> “He was the team representative, that is to ****say****, he spoke on behalf of the group.”

「他是團隊代表, ****也就是說****, 他代表整個團體發言。」

****that is to say = 用另一種方式更清楚地解釋剛才的內容****

Slightly formal.

22. ****needless to say**(不用說) — 不用說;當然******

A very common fixed expression.

Practice 44

> “**Needless to say**, I was nervous.”

「**不用說**，我當時很緊張。」

Practice 45

> “**Needless to say**, everyone was relieved when it ended.”

「**不用說**，結束後大家都鬆了一口氣。」

needless to say = 後面的事實非常明顯／可以預期，因此幾乎不用特別解釋

23. **to say the least (至少可以這樣說／往輕裡說) — 至少可以說；說得保守一點**

Practice 46

> “The experience was challenging, **to say the least**.”

「這次經歷**至少可以說**是非常有挑戰性。」

Practice 47

> “He was surprised, **to say the least**.”

「**說得保守一點**，他當時非常驚訝。」

to say the least = 表示實際情況可能比剛才的描述更強烈

24. **not to say + stronger word (甚至可以說) — 甚至可以說**

A somewhat formal construction.

Practice 48

> “The audience looked concerned, **not to say** alarmed.”

「觀眾看起來很擔心，**甚至可以說有點驚慌**。」

Practice 49

> “The instructions were confusing, **not to say** misleading.”

「那些指示很混亂，**甚至可以說有誤導性**。」

not to say + stronger description = 補上一個更強烈、更進一步的描述

More formal/literary.

25. **say what you mean / mean what you say (說真心話／說到做到) — 說出真正意思／認真對待自己說的話**

Practice 50

> “Try to **say what you mean** clearly.”

「盡量清楚**說出你真正想表達的意思**。」

Practice 51

> “When she promises something, she **means what she says**.”

「她作出承諾時，**她說的話是認真的**。」

say what you mean = 把真正意思清楚表達出來

This is useful in communication contexts.

26. **have a say (有發言權／決定權) — 有發言權；有份決定**

Now **say** functions as a noun.

Practice 52

> “Employees should **have a say** in decisions that affect them.”

「員工應該在影響自己的決定上**有發言權**。」

Practice 53

> “I had no **say** in the final decision.”

「我對最終決定**沒有發言權／決定權**。」

have a say = 有權表達意見, 並可能影響決定

27. **have the final say** (有最終決定權) — 有最後決定權

Practice 54

> “Senior management has the **final say**.”

「高層管理層擁有**最終決定權**。」

Practice 55

> “The client has the **final say** on the design.”

「客戶對設計擁有**最後決定權**。」

have the final say = 對某件事擁有最後、最高的決定權

This is not simply “speak last.”

28. **say** = opinion/voice in decision-making (發言權) — 意見; 決定權

Practice 56

> “Everyone should get a **say**.”

「每個人都應該有**表達意見的機會**。」

Practice 57

> “Parents want more of a **say** in school policy.”

「家長希望對學校政策有更多**發言權／參與決策權**。」

****a say = 參與表達意見或作決定的權利／影響力****

29. ****saying = common expression/proverb (俗語／說法) — 諺語; 俗語; 常用說法****

A major related noun.

Practice 58

> “There’s an old ****saying****: practice makes perfect.”

「有一句古老的****俗語****: 熟能生巧。」

Practice 59

> “Do you know the ****saying**** ‘better late than never’?”

「你知道『遲做總比不做好』這句****諺語／俗語****嗎？」

****a saying = 人們經常引用、通常表達某種生活智慧或普遍觀察的固定說法****

30. ****as the saying goes (俗語有云) — 正如俗語所說****

Practice 60

> “As the ****saying goes****, practice makes perfect.”

「****正如俗語所說****, 熟能生巧。」

Practice 61

> “As the old ****saying goes****, nothing ventured, nothing gained.”

「****俗語有云****, 不入虎穴, 焉得虎子。」

****as the saying goes = 用來引出一句常見俗語／諺語****

31. ****go without saying (不言而喻) — 不用說; 不言而喻****

A very useful fixed expression.

Practice 62

> “It **goes without saying** that preparation matters.”

「充分準備很重要, 這是**不言而喻的**。」

Practice 63

> “It **goes without saying** that confidential information should be protected.”

「機密資料應受到保護, 這是**不用說也知道的**。」

it goes without saying that... = 某個事實非常明顯、理所當然, 不需要特別說明

32. **say** = command/instruction in reported language (吩咐／要求; 特定語境) — 說要; 指示

Although **tell** is often more natural when there is a person object, **say** can report instructions through content.

Practice 64

> “The email **said to arrive** by nine.”

「電郵**寫明要**在九點前到達。」

Practice 65

> “The instructions **say to press** this button.”

「指示**寫明要按**這個按鈕。」

say to do something = 文字／訊息指示要做某事

This is especially natural when the subject is:

* instructions;

* notice;

* message.

33. **what does that say about...?(這反映了甚麼?) — 這說明／反映甚麼? **

A figurative meaning.

Practice 66

> “What does that **say about** the company culture?”

「這件事**反映了公司文化甚麼問題**？」

Practice 67

> “His reaction **says a lot about** his character.”

「他的反應**很能反映他的性格**。」

something says something about X = 某件事反映、顯示或透露 X 的特徵／情況

No literal speech is required.

34. **say a lot / say something about(很能說明) — 反映很多; 說明**

Practice 68

> “Her calm response **says a lot about** her confidence.”

「她冷靜的反應**很能反映她的自信**。」

Practice 69

> “The result **says something about** the quality of the preparation.”

「結果**某程度上說明了準備工作的質素**。」

say something/a lot about = 某個行為、結果或事實能間接反映某種特質

35. **say = suppose/assume for discussion(假定) — 假設; 假定**

Closely related to **let's say**, but can stand alone.

Practice 70

> “**Say** you make a mistake halfway through—what then?”

「**假設**你講到一半犯了錯，那怎麼辦？」

Practice 71

> “**Say** the audience is larger than expected.”

「**假設**觀眾人數比預期多。」

say + hypothetical clause = 假設某種情況成立，以便繼續討論

Conversational.

36. **say = approximately (大約) — 比方說; 大概**

Practice 72

> “Give yourself, **say**, twenty minutes to practise.”

「給自己**比如說／大約**二十分鐘練習。」

Practice 73

> “We need, **say**, three examples.”

「我們需要**大概／例如**三個例子。」

say + number/example = 提出一個大概數值／例子，而不是精確指定

37. **what do you say? (你覺得怎樣？／如何？) — 你意下如何？**

A common conversational expression.

Practice 74

> “Shall we practise once more? What do you **say**?”

「我們再練一次好嗎？你**覺得怎樣**？」

Practice 75

> “Let’s take a break. What do you **say**?”

「我們休息一下吧。你**意下如何**？」

what do you say? = 詢問對方是否同意某項建議／邀請

38. **I must say / I have to say (不得不說) — 我得說; 老實說**

A common discourse expression.

Practice 76

> “I must **say**, you handled the situation very well.”

「我**得說**, 你處理得非常好。」

Practice 77

> “I have to **say**, I was impressed.”

「我**不得不說**, 我很有印象。」

I must/have to say = 用來引出自己想特別強調的意見或反應

39. **say no more (不用再說／我懂了) — 不用多說; 明白了**

An informal fixed expression.

Practice 78

> “You need someone to check the slides?”

> “**Say no more.**”

「你需要有人幫你檢查投影片？」

「**不用多說，我明白了。**」

Practice 79

> “The meeting was three hours long.”

> “**Say no more.**”

「會議長達三小時。」

「**不用再說，我懂你的意思了。**」

say no more = 已經有足夠資訊理解對方暗示，不必再解釋

Informal.

Important distinction: **say vs speak**

This is crucial.

say

focuses on **the words/content**:

> “What did she say?”

= 她說了甚麼？

speak

focuses on:

* the act of speaking;

* speaking ability;

* addressing someone/an audience.

> “She spoke clearly.”

= 她說話很清楚。

> “She speaks English.”

= 她會說英語。

So:

****say = 說了甚麼****

****speak = 說話這個動作／能力****

Important distinction: **say vs tell**

Another classic learner contrast.

**say**

normally takes the words/content:

> “She said something.”

> “She said that she was nervous.”

If a person follows:

> “She said it ****to me****.”

**tell**

normally takes a person directly:

> “She ****told me**** the truth.”

> “She ****told me**** that she was nervous.”

So:

>  say something to someone

>  tell someone something

Avoid:

>  say me

Important distinction: ****say vs talk****

****say****

focuses on a specific message:

> “He said no.”

****talk****

focuses more on conversation/discussion:

> “We talked about the project.”

So:

****say = 說出內容****

****talk = 交談／討論****

Important distinction: ****say no vs refuse****

****say no****

is everyday and often emphasizes the response:

> “I said no.”

****refuse****

is more direct/formal and emphasizes rejection:

> “I refused the offer.”

In your passage:

> ****if I said no****

naturally means:

****if I refused the opportunity****

but sounds more personal and conversational.

Important distinction: **say yes vs agree**

**say yes**

can mean:

- * accept an invitation/opportunity;
- * respond positively.

**agree**

means:

- * share an opinion;
- * consent to a plan/proposal.

Compare:

> “She said yes to the job.”

= 她接受了工作。

> “She agreed with my opinion.”

= 她同意我的看法。

Not identical.

Important distinction: **say vs state**

**say**

is broad and everyday.

**state**

is more formal and deliberate:

> “The report states that...”

= 報告指出.....

For professional or academic writing, **state** can sound more formal than **say**.

Important distinction: say vs mention

say

= express content.

mention

= refer briefly to something without necessarily discussing it fully.

> “She said the project was difficult.”

= 她說項目很難。

> “She mentioned the project.”

= 她提到那個項目。

Important distinction: say vs pronounce

say a word

= produce the word orally in context.

pronounce a word

= specifically produce its sounds in a particular way.

> “How do you say this word?”

can mean:

* what word/expression should I use?

* how is it said?

But:

> “How do you pronounce this word?”

specifically asks about pronunciation.

Important distinction: **the sign says vs the sign reads**

Both are natural.

> “The sign says ‘Exit.’”

> “The sign reads ‘Exit.’”

Both:

「標誌寫著『出口』。」

Reads is somewhat more formal/literary.

Important distinction: **say = opinion vs say = estimate**

Compare:

> “I’d say the plan is good.”

= 我認為計劃不錯。

> “I’d say about 200 people attended.”

= 我估計約二百人出席。

Same pattern, but one is judgment and one is numerical estimation.

Important distinction: **say so vs think so**

say so

= actually express the statement.

> “If you disagree, say so.”

= 如果不同意，就說出來。

think so

= believe the statement internally.

> “I think so.”

= 我想是這樣。

So:

say so = 說出來

think so = 心裡認為如此

Important distinction: **have a say vs say something**

say something

= actually speak.

have a say

= possess the right/opportunity to influence a decision.

You can:

> have a say

even before you actually say anything.

So:

****have a say = 有發言／決策權****

not simply:

****說了一句話****

Important distinction: **saying vs phrase**

**saying**

usually means a common proverb-like expression containing a general observation/wisdom.

**phrase**

is simply a group of words functioning as a unit.

Not every phrase is a saying.

Important distinction: **needless to say vs it goes without saying**

Both mean:

> 不用說／不言而喻

**Needless to say**

often introduces the obvious result directly.

**It goes without saying that...**

forms a complete clause and can sound slightly more formal.

Important distinction: **say no more vs never mind**

**say no more**

= I understand the implication; no need to explain further.

never mind

= forget it / don't worry / it no longer matters.

Different discourse functions.

Family-extension sweep

The practical **say** family is rich in reported speech, responses, written indication, opinions, approximation, and fixed expressions:

- * **say something** = 說出某內容
- * **say yes/no** = 答應／拒絕
- * **say that + clause** = 說／表示.....
- * **say something to someone** = 對某人說某事
- * **say — opinion** = 表達看法
- * **I'd say** = 我認為／我估計
- * **say — approximate** = 大約／比如說
- * **let's say** = 假設／比方說
- * **sign/email/report says** = 寫著／指出／顯示
- * **say a word/name** = 說出某個詞／名字
- * **say hello/goodbye/thanks/sorry** = 打招呼／道別／道謝／道歉
- * **say so** = 這樣說／明說
- * **if you say so** = 既然你這樣說／你說是就是吧
- * **who says...?** = 誰說.....？／質疑某假設
- * **you can say that again** = 完全同意
- * **that's not to say** = 這並不是說.....
- * **that is to say** = 也就是說
- * **needless to say** = 不用說
- * **to say the least** = 至少可以這樣說
- * **have a say** = 有發言／決定權
- * **have the final say** = 有最終決定權
- * **a saying** = 俗語／諺語
- * **as the saying goes** = 正如俗語所說
- * **go without saying** = 不言而喻
- * **say something about** = 反映／說明
- * **what do you say?** = 你意下如何？
- * **I must say** = 我得說
- * **say no more** = 不用多說／我懂了

The main semantic branches are:

> **express words/content**

> **give a response**

> **state an opinion**

> **indicate through text/data**

> **estimate / suppose**

> **have influence in a decision**

plus a large family of discourse expressions.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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say — express words/content	用說話表達具體內容、句子或訊息
say yes/no	用肯定／否定回答表示接受、同意或拒絕
say that + clause	用語言陳述某項資訊、意見或事實
say something to someone	把某段具體內容說給某人聽
say — opinion	表達自己的判斷、看法或評價
I'd say	以較委婉方式提出個人意見、判斷或估計
say — approximately	提出一個大概數字、例子或估算, 而非精確指定
let's say	提出假設情況, 方便繼續討論、估算或舉例
sign/email/report says	某段文字、標誌、文件或資料載有／顯示某項內容
say a word/name	把某個詞、名稱或短語用聲音說出來
say hello/goodbye/thanks/sorry	用語言作出招呼、道別、感謝或道歉等社交表達
say so	說出前面所提到的那個意見／內容, 避免重複完整句子
if you say so	表示暫時接受對方說法, 有時帶懷疑或不完全信服
who says...?	質疑某個假設、規則或普遍看法是否真的成立
you can say that again	強烈表示同意對方剛才的說法
that's not to say	防止前面說法被過度理解; 這並不表示.....
that is to say	用另一種方式更清楚解釋剛才內容; 也就是說
needless to say	後面的事實非常明顯／可預期, 因此不用特別說明
to say the least	表示實際情況可能比剛才的描述更強烈
have a say	有權表達意見, 並可能影響決定
have the final say	對某件事情擁有最後／最高的決定權
a saying	人們經常引用、通常表達普遍觀察或生活智慧的固定說法
as the saying goes	用來引出常見俗語／諺語
go without saying	某個事實非常明顯、理所當然, 不需要特別說明

say something/a lot about	某個行為、結果或事實能間接反映某種特質／情況	
what do you say?	詢問對方是否同意某項建議／邀請；你意下如何？	
I must/have to say	用來引出自己想特別強調的意見或反應	
say no more	表示資訊已足夠理解暗示，不必再進一步解釋	

For your original passage

> “I felt that if I ****said no****, I would regret it later.”

The exact meaning is:

****say = 用說話表達一個回答／態度****

and specifically:

****say no = 表示拒絕、不接受這個機會****

Therefore:

> ****if I said no****

= ****「如果我拒絕了／如果我選擇不接受這個機會」****

The meaning is slightly broader than literally pronouncing the word *****“no.”*****

You could have refused in different words, but English still naturally describes the decision as:

> ****say no to the opportunity****

So the core mapping in your passage is:

****say no = 拒絕／不接受****

The most important learner contrasts are:

> ****say something****

> = 說出某段內容

> ****say no****

> = 拒絕

> ****say yes****

> = 答應／接受

> **say that you're nervous**

> = 說自己很緊張

> **say something to someone**

> = 對某人說某事

> **the email says...**

> = 電郵寫著／指出.....

> **I'd say about 200 people**

> = 我估計大約二百人

> **let's say...**

> = 假設／比如說

> **have a say**

> = 有發言權／決定權

> **a saying**

> = 俗語／諺語

So **say** is much richer than simply:

> **say = 說**

and in your original sentence, **say no** functions as a natural everyday way of expressing:

“refuse or decline the opportunity.”